GridTech Hackathon: Judging Rubric

Columbia Energy Symposium | October 24, 2026

Scoring guidance

Each judge scores every team on the five criteria below, using whole numbers from 1 (weakest) to 5 (strongest). Scores of 2 and 4 are for work that falls between the anchor descriptions.

Each judge records a one-line justification for every score.

Judges score from each team's 5-minute presentation and demo; there is no hands-on time with the tools. Score what you can see and hear, not what you would need to verify. Judge each team against the priorities and requirements it states in its demo; there is no single correct customer. Score how well the tool handles each dimension, not whether the benchmark numbers are correct or the portfolio is the best one. Visual polish is not scored.

Weighted scores are calculated automatically on each judge's tab and combined on the Summary tab. Shaded cells are for input.

#	Criterion	Weight	What it assesses	5 (Strong)	3 (Adequate)	1 (Weak)
1	**Product**	20%	Whether the product works, is easy to follow, and would help a developer make a decision.	The demo is flexible to changing inputs, is able to separate hard requirements from preferences and explains trade-offs and rationale. A non-technical viewer can follow it easily and intuitively.	Main features work, but the demo needs workarounds, requirements and preferences blur together, or changes and conflicts are handled unclearly. A developer would need more information before acting.	The tool is largely non-functional, does not respond to changes, or only the builders could make sense of it.
2	**Methodology**	20%	Whether a judge can see how the tool turns customer answers into a recommendation and challenge the assumptions behind it.	The team's methodology is well explained, both verbally and intuitively through the product design. Key assumptions, including Energy, finance, and carbon are intuitively explained through the product itself. Methodological trade-offs are easily understood.	Some of the logic and assumptions are visible, but how an input changes a result is only partly explained, business assumptions are mixed into cost, or claims like "earliest feasible" are not supported.	Logic is a black box. The team cannot explain why results change.
3	**Portfolio viability**	20%	Whether the team clearly presents a portfolio that follows from the priorities entered in the demo, including its grid-stress response, and what an alternative gains or gives up. The tool produces a portfolio that meets all requirements and fits within all constraints.	Load: The team clearly presents the portfolio, when initial service starts and when full demand is reached, and explains how it covers the campus load. Reliability: The team shows how the portfolio responds during grid-stress periods and what is relocated or interrupted. Alternatives: The team shows at least one meaningful alternative, what it gains or gives up in capacity, reliability, or speed to power, and when it	Load: The portfolio and service start are presented, but how it covers the campus load is only partly explained. Reliability: The grid-stress response is shown, but how protected demand and import limits are handled is unclear. Alternatives: An alternative is shown, but what it gains or gives up, or when it would be better, must be inferred.	The portfolio or service timing is unclear, the grid-stress response is not shown, or only a single answer is presented with no alternatives.
4	**Financial outcomes**	20%	How clearly the tool shows what the recommendation costs for the priorities entered, and what an alternative costs.	Annualized cost, volumetric pricing, and acute pricing spikes are clearly shown. Technical or weather-related interruptions are explained and mitigated financially. Alternatives with pros and cons are explained in clear financial terms.	Cost results are shown, but their drivers, the separate treatment of business assumptions, relocation and interruption costs, or the premium of the alternative must be inferred.	Costs are missing or unexplained, with no sense of what different choices cost.

5	**Environmental outcomes**	20%	How clearly the tool shows the environmental results for the priorities entered, and what cleaner supply costs or delays.	Carbon emissions, annual clean energy share, and any earned clean energy attributes are explained both quantitatively and qualitatively. Teams address how environmental outcomes change under various technology and reliability assumptions and what trade-offs were made in order to preserve the achieved environmental outcomes.	Environmental results are shown, but how they connect to the priorities entered, how relocation and interruption are treated, or what improving them costs must be inferred.	Environmental results are missing or unexplained, with no view of how they trade off against cost or speed.
	Total	**100%**				